

12 weeks

is how much **unpaid time** off of work **new parents** can take if eligible for the Family and Medical Leave Act.

having a baby with birth defects or with a low birth weight. One study has also made a link between mothers who were stressed during pregnancy and introversion or hyperactivity in their children as they grow up. To help reduce stress levels, be sure to take your lunch break (rather than working through it), walk around the block to clear your head, and leave on time—at least for some of the week. You could also ask for extra help and delegate tasks where you can, in order to manage and streamline your workload effectively.

Q I want to go back to work after the baby is born—can I do that right away?

There are no US guidelines about when you can return to work, because there are no nationwide rules on maternity leave. In the UK, mothers can't return to work during the aptly named "recovery period," two weeks after the baby is born. (This gives women time to recover from childbirth.) If you can afford a few weeks off, take it.

Q I told my employer that I wanted 6 weeks off after birth, but now I'd like 12 weeks. Is this a problem?

Decisions about your maternity leave are very individualized, since they're made between you and your boss or human resources representative. You'll need to speak with your boss or HR representative as soon as you change your mind about the time frame for returning to work to see if they'll agree to your plan. If your company offers paid maternity leave for six weeks, you may be able to use sick or vacation leave for the additional time, or you might use unpaid FMLA leave for the remainder.

Q How can I keep healthy during a long, exhausting day at the office?

It is likely that a typical eight-hour work day will affect you differently when you are pregnant, particularly during the most tiring first and last trimesters. Fortunately, a few minor adjustments in the way you work can help.



» **Use your lunch break** to eat and rest, not run errands. Take time to sit in a park or café in order to switch off from any stress at work.



» **Set up your workstation** correctly and adopt good posture. You may need to readjust the position of your chair and computer as your pregnancy progresses.



» **Take frequent, short breaks** away from your desk. A short stroll every 45 minutes can help you avoid acidity and heartburn. Stretching can prevent aches.



» **Drink water** and eat small healthy snacks, such as fruit and nuts, throughout the day. This will keep energy reserves high and combat any nausea.



» **Choose comfortable clothing** and footwear. Wearing layers of natural, breathable fabrics will help you adjust to any fluctuations of body temperature.



» **Stagger your commute** by asking your employer if you can work slightly different hours to beat the rush hour—which can be challenging whether you are driving or using public transportation.



» **Keep housework** and cooking to a minimum in the evenings—this time is essential for relaxation so ask your partner or family members to help you out.



» **Go to bed early** whenever you are able.

